base in Guantánamo. “In a stroke, Clinton turned Cubans into the legal equivalent of Haitians,” the *Washington Post* noted in wonderment.[40] By the end of 1994 some 50,000 refugees were housed there, at a cost of $500,000 to $1 million a day.[41] But when Cubans saw that their guarantee of automatic entry into the United States had evaporated, the numbers leaving declined precipitously.

Most of the Cubans sent to Guantánamo were eventually admitted to the United States. But Clinton was also forced to acknowledge the noxious effects of the U.S. policy, in effect since the 1966 Cuban Adjustment Act (CAA). In May of 1995, he announced the new “Wet Foot, Dry Foot” policy. Cubans picked up at sea would, like would-be immigrants without visas from anywhere else in the world, be returned home. Those who managed to arrive on land – whether from the Straits, or through Mexico – with “dry feet,” would still be granted the preferential treatment and almost automatic refugee status conferred by the CAA. He also agreed to facilitate the visa-granting process, to encourage Cubans to enter legally. Cuba, for its part, agreed to restore its policy of intercepting unauthorized rafters.

Brothers to the Rescue, deprived of its raison-d’être but still in possession of numerous aircraft, revived the 1960s tactic of Havana flyovers, dropping leaflets calling on the Cuban population to rebel. The Cuban government protested regularly to the United States about violations of its airspace and, in early 1996, shot down a small plane, killing its pilot. The Cubans claimed that the plane was inside Cuban airspace, which Brothers to the Rescue denied. The ensuing outrage encouraged the U.S. Congress to pass the Helms–Burton legislation, tightening and expanding the U.S. embargo against Cuba. Relations further soured in 1998, when U.S. authorities arrested five Cuban intelligence agents who had infiltrated organizations like Brothers to the Rescue and Alpha 66. The Cubans argued that the agents were not spying on the United States, but rather on terrorist organizations planning attacks on their country. They had even shared information with the FBI. But the Cuban Five remained in jail as of early 2010, becoming something of an international cause célèbre.[42]